

Between the Stop and the Target

A TRADER'S AFFIRMATION HANDBOOK

*Clear thinking and steady words for the moments that test every
trader*



HARVEST WRIGHT

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Illustrations created for this edition.

First edition

How to Use This Book

This handbook is meant to sit beside your trading screen rather than on a shelf. Each chapter covers a specific moment that tends to unsettle traders, from the frustration of watching a move happen without you to the quiet overconfidence that follows a run of wins. You can read it from front to back once, but it is written to be opened at the right page when you need it.

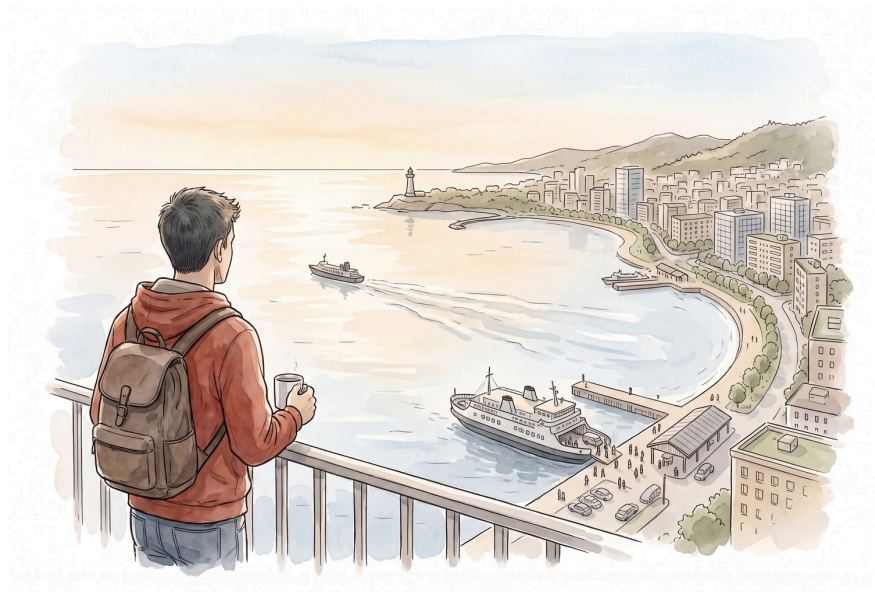
Every chapter follows the same shape. A short line tells you when to read it, and a few paragraphs describe the situation and explain what is going on beneath the emotion, because feelings in trading tend to settle once the logic behind them is laid out plainly. Each chapter ends with an affirmation of a couple of sentences. Read it aloud if you can, slowly, and more than once if the first reading does not land.

The affirmations work best when they are true for you. They are written around sound trading practice, meaning a defined plan, consistent risk and honest review, and if you do not yet have those in place, several chapters will point you toward building them. An affirmation can steady you in the moment, while the plan is what protects your account over time.

This book is about the ordinary pressures of trading, and it is no substitute for proper support. If trading has started to feel compulsive, if you are risking money you cannot afford to lose, or if the stress is spilling into your sleep, health or relationships in a way that does not ease, please speak to someone you trust or to a qualified professional. Stepping back to look after yourself is always a sound trading decision.

CHAPTER 1

Waking Up to a Move I Wasn't In



WHEN TO READ THIS

You check the charts in the morning and find a large overnight or pre-market move that happened while you were asleep.

You open the chart with your coffee and see that price has already travelled a long way, perhaps straight through the level you were planning to trade from today. The first reaction is often a sinking feeling that the day's opportunity has gone, followed by an urge to find some way to get involved before it moves any further.

WHAT'S REALLY HAPPENING

Markets move around the clock, and no trader can be present for every hour of it. A move that happened overnight belongs to the traders who were awake and positioned for it, and it was never

part of your plan in the first place. Your account is unchanged, and the session you prepared for has not started yet.

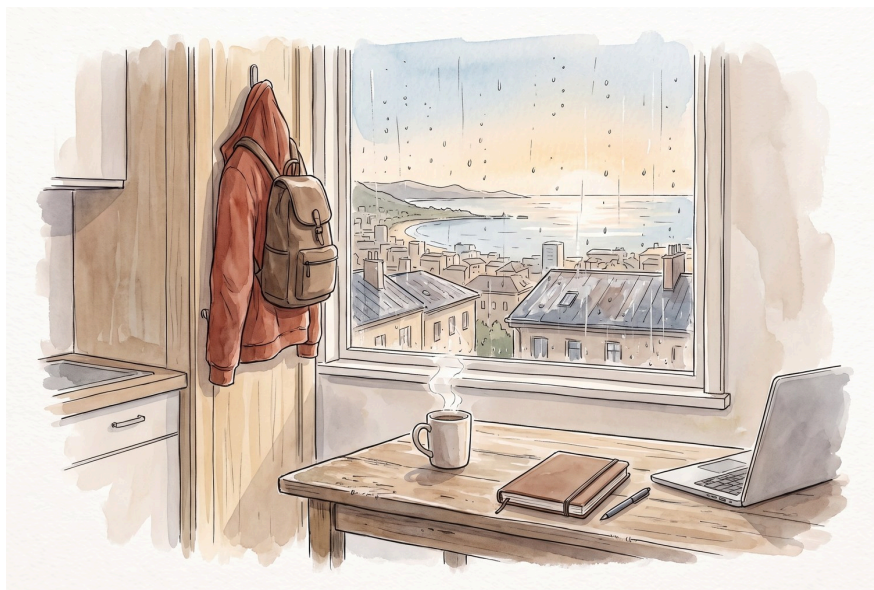
The danger in this moment is letting the overnight move rewrite your plan in a hurry. Traders who wake up to a big gap often jump in at the open to catch up, entering at stretched prices with no clear level to risk against. A large overnight move usually creates new structure to work with, such as a gap to watch, a fresh high or low, or a level that may be retested, and those only become useful once you have taken the time to mark them calmly.

Treat the morning as fresh preparation. Update your levels, decide what price would need to do for you to take part, and accept that the best trades of the day may come later, after the opening volatility has settled.

AFFIRMATION

What happened while I slept was never mine to take, and my account is exactly as I left it. I will look at the market in front of me with fresh eyes and trade only what today's plan allows.

The Morning After a Bad Day



WHEN TO READ THIS

You are about to start a session the day after a heavy loss or a day you traded badly.

Yesterday is still close. You may have slept poorly and replayed the worst trades on the way to bed, and now you have woken with either a knot in your stomach or a quiet determination to make it all back today. Neither of those feelings is a good trading partner.

WHAT'S REALLY HAPPENING

The market has no memory of your last session. It will not hand you easy trades because you had a hard day, and it will not punish you twice for the same mistakes. The only thing carrying yesterday into today is you, which means you have more control over this morning than it feels like.

The common trap is treating today as a repair job. When the goal becomes recovering a number, position sizes creep up and standards drop, and every trade ends up carrying the weight of the one before it. A better aim for the morning after is a clean session, where you follow your rules on every trade regardless of the result. Many experienced traders deliberately trade smaller the day after a large loss so they can rebuild rhythm without extra pressure.

If you did not review yesterday properly, take ten minutes to do it now. Write down what happened and what you would do differently, then close the journal. Once the lesson is on paper, you no longer need to carry it around in your head during the session.

AFFIRMATION

Yesterday is finished, and the lesson from it is written down where it belongs. Today asks only that I trade my plan well, one decision at a time, with no debt to repay to the market or to myself.

Pre-Open Nerves



WHEN TO READ THIS

The minutes before the open, when your heart is racing and your hands feel restless.

The session is about to start and your body has decided it is an emergency. Your pulse is up and your attention keeps jumping between charts. Part of you wants the open to hurry up while another part wants to delay it.

WHAT'S REALLY HAPPENING

Nervousness before the open is a physical response to uncertainty, and it shows up in beginners and professionals alike. Your body is preparing for something it senses matters, and a certain amount of that alertness can sharpen your focus. The problem comes

when the nerves start making decisions, pushing you to act quickly just to release the tension.

The open is also one of the most volatile parts of the day, which means it rewards patience more than speed. Nothing requires you to trade in the first minute or the first fifteen. Some traders set a rule to observe the opening range before considering any entry, and that rule alone removes much of the pressure to be ready at the bell.

A few slow breaths help more than most people expect. Breathing out for longer than you breathe in signals to your nervous system that the situation is safe. Read your plan once more, remind yourself of your maximum risk for the day, and let the first minutes pass without needing to act.

AFFIRMATION

The nerves I feel are my body preparing for something that matters to me, and I can let them settle without obeying them. My plan is already made, so I can watch the open calmly and act only when price gives me a reason.

Needing Today to Pay the Bills



WHEN TO READ THIS

You sit down to trade feeling that today's result has to cover rent, bills or some other pressing expense.

There is a number in your head before the session begins, and it is attached to something real, such as a bill that is due or a shortfall that needs covering. Every setup now looks like a way to reach that number, and every loss feels like it takes you further from something you need.

WHAT'S REALLY HAPPENING

The market pays out according to probability, and it pays no attention to what you need this week. A strategy with a real edge still produces losing days and weeks, and sometimes whole losing months, and those periods arrive with no regard for your bills.

When a single day's trading must produce a specific amount, you are asking a probabilistic process to behave like a salary, and it cannot.

Needing the money changes how you trade. Traders under this pressure take marginal setups, hold losers longer in the hope they come back, and cut winners early to lock in something. Each of these habits wears away the edge that makes trading worthwhile in the first place, so the pressure to earn tends to make earning harder.

The honest response is to separate your living expenses from your trading as far as you can. That may mean building a cash buffer that covers several months of costs, keeping other income while you develop, or reducing size until the outcome of any one day stops mattering to your household. None of this is a quick fix, but it is the foundation that lets you trade freely.

AFFIRMATION

My trading is a long process measured over many sessions, and no single day has to carry my needs. I trade today at a size that lets me think clearly, and I trust the steady work of good decisions more than the pressure of a number.

CHAPTER 5

The Big News Day (FOMC, CPI, NFP)



WHEN TO READ THIS

A high-impact release is scheduled and you feel anxious about trading around it.

The economic calendar is marked in red today. You know price could move violently in either direction and spreads may widen, so a normal-looking trade could be blown apart in seconds. Part of you wants to catch the big move, and part of you wants to hide.

WHAT'S REALLY HAPPENING

News releases concentrate uncertainty into a short window. The first reaction is often fast and erratic and prone to reversing, and even traders who correctly predict the data can lose money on how the market chooses to interpret it. Slippage and wider spreads mean your stop may fill well beyond where you set it.

This is a situation where your plan should make the decision in advance. Many traders stay flat for a set period before and after major releases, close or reduce open positions, or wait for the first reaction to settle before looking for structure. Any of these can be sound, and what matters is choosing one ahead of time so you are not deciding under the pressure of a spike.

Sitting out a news event is a legitimate trading decision. The big candles that print on these days look like missed opportunities in hindsight, but they also contain many traders who were stopped out, slipped badly or chased the wrong direction. There will be tradeable structure after the dust settles, and your edge will still be there.

AFFIRMATION

*I decided how to handle this release before it arrived, and I will follow that decision whatever the first candles do.
Standing aside is a choice I am allowed to make, and my patience today protects the account I have worked to build.*

You have read five of the 137.

The full handbook covers the whole trading day and the whole trading life: the open, the trade, the aftermath, funded challenges, the people around you, and the long road.

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Paperback and Kindle on Amazon.

Details and the latest link:

r2ftrading.com/handbook

Harvest trades NQ live every weekday at the London open.

Schedule in your time zone: r2ftrading.com/live